

Field Visit Report – Navagamuhena Tea Factory

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Report Summary

Location: Navagamuhena Tea Factory

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A field visit was conducted to Navagamuhena Tea Factory to gain an understanding of the factory's operational processes, existing software solutions, and potential software requirements. The visit provided valuable insights into how technology is currently being utilized within the tea manufacturing industry and helped identify opportunities for the proposed Tea Collection Management System.

Purpose and Scope

Purpose

- Understand the workflow and operations of a tea factory.
- Identify software-related challenges and requirements from the factory's perspective.
- Evaluate existing technological solutions used within the industry.
- Validate the market demand for a tea collection management solution.

Scope

- Current software systems used by the factory.
- Stakeholder interactions within the tea collection process.
- Technological adoption within factory operations, including payment and salary handling.
- Potential areas where the proposed system could provide additional value.

Observations

- The factory uses a customized software solution to manage several activities, and access is controlled through role-based permissions.
- Details of tea collection agents and estate owners are stored in the system, but they do not have direct access to the software.
- The factory makes monthly payments to estate owners for supplied tea, after deducting advance amounts and fertilizer costs.
- Salary payment details are prepared by the factory accountant and sent to the bank for processing.
- The factory keeps a manual error book to record system errors and also stores screenshots or pictures of those errors.

- Some data is still collected manually first, such as employee attendance and tea leaf weights, before entering it into the system.

Data Collected

- Information about the factory's existing software system and how it is used.
- Details of user roles and access control within the system.
- Records related to tea collection agents, estate owners, and factory administration.
- Information about monthly payments, deductions, and financial handling.
- Salary payment process and bank-related documentation.
- Error recording method, including manual error book entries and screenshots of issues.
- Manual data collection methods for attendance and tea leaf weight records.

Key Findings

- The factory already has a digital system, but it is mainly used for internal management and selected stakeholders.
- Tea estate owners and collecting agents are included in the records, but they are not fully connected to the system.
- Financial activities and salary processing are handled separately from the main operational system.
- The factory still depends on manual steps for some activities, showing that the process is not fully automated.
- There is a clear need for a more comprehensive system that connects more stakeholders and reduces manual work.
- Error tracking is currently manual, which suggests the existing system still needs improvement and better support.

Recommendations and Action Items

- Conduct field visits to additional tea factories to broaden the requirements baseline.
- Investigate options for direct system access or a simplified interface for estate owners and collecting agents.
- Explore digitizing the manual error book into a structured error-logging feature within the proposed system.
- Assess opportunities to reduce manual data entry for attendance and tea leaf weight recording, such as through digital weighing or mobile data capture.
- Evaluate the feasibility of integrating payment, deduction, and salary processing into a unified platform.

Follow-Ups

- Schedule visits to additional tea factories.
- Conduct interviews with factory owners and administrators.
- Gather detailed requirements from estate owners, collecting agents, and receiving agents.
- Analyze existing software solutions used within the industry, including role-based access models.
- Refine system requirements based on findings from future visits.
- Prepare a comparative analysis of requirements across multiple factories.

Conclusion

The visit to Navagamuhena Tea Factory confirmed that the factory already relies on a customized, role-based software system for several of its operations, but that estate owners and collecting agents remain outside direct access to it, and key activities such as attendance tracking, tea leaf weighing, and error logging are still handled manually. The proposed Tea Collection Management System offers an opportunity to connect these stakeholders more directly, reduce manual processes, and provide a more structured approach to error tracking and financial handling. Further field visits are necessary to understand varying factory requirements and ensure that the proposed system addresses industry-wide needs effectively.